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THE WHITE HOUSE
WASHINGTON
August 5, 1995

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INFORMATION

MEMORANDUM FOR THE PRESIDENT

FROM: ANTHONY LAKE

SUBJECT: Balkan Strategy: Options for Discussion at Foreign Policy Group Meeting, August 7, 1995

Principals have taken forward the review you requested of long-term strategy for resolving the Balkan conflict. We asked agencies to reflect on where we want to be in 12-18 months -- the "end state" that would best serve U.S. interests -- and then determine how to get there. Agencies have written papers reflecting alternative approaches, which are attached. I thought you might want to review them before Monday's meeting.

The policy review has revealed a great deal of common ground:

- Everyone agrees we should make a determined effort to reach a political settlement in the coming weeks, taking advantage of the window of opportunity provided by NATO's and UNPROFOR's renewed resolve, as well as by Serb (and Allied) anxieties about the shifting strategic balance in the wake of Croatia's military action.
 - The settlement would adhere to the central principles of the Contact Group plan but with a more realistic map, maximum autonomy for the two entities and, possibly, an option for the Serbs to secede peacefully after 2-3 years.
 - It would require that the U.S. reassume a leadership role in the negotiations and break the freeze on contacts with Pale. (The NSC paper provides a detailed description of a modified Contact Group plan and how to achieve it; all agencies agree with this basic approach, although State has reservations about certain aspects.)
- All agree that, if a settlement cannot be reached and/or if UNPROFOR's credibility continues to erode, then we should pull the plug, fulfill our commitment to help UNPROFOR withdraw, lift the arms embargo and move to a post-withdrawal strategy. Muddling through is no longer an option.
- All agree as well that we cannot walk away after UNPROFOR leaves and that we need to provide some degree of support (arms, training, air strikes, economic aid) to help ensure the survival of a Bosnian state for the Muslims and Croats.

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cc: Vice President
Chief of Staff

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- All agree that our continued engagement should be conditioned on prior understandings with the Bosnian government.

While all agree on the need to support a viable Bosnian state, the major difference among Principals is over its dimensions:

- Madeleine Albright and I believe that we should continue to support the preservation of a Bosnia-Herzegovina along lines broadly consistent with the principles and goals of the Contact Group plan (i.e., a single state, with the Muslims and Croats controlling roughly half of the territory, give or take 5%).
 - We feel anything less would be tantamount to ratifying aggression and would, in any case, be rejected by Sarajevo -- leading to continued instability and a revanchist Bosnian state.
 - Madeleine makes the additional point that failure to support a viable Bosnia would undermine U.S. leadership in NATO and the Islamic world and overshadow all the Administration's other accomplishments.
- State and Defense argue for a more limited commitment: that we should only help the Bosnians consolidate control over the territory they now possess, with some modest adjustments for viability (particularly around Sarajevo). They believe that the costs of supporting Bosnian efforts to recover territory would be too great, the prospects too uncertain, and that it would risk serious strains in relations with our Allies and with Russia.

While the choice between these two end-states is a political one, it will affect the nature and scope of the military support that we would need to provide. (All agree, however, that we should draw the line at ground forces, although Madeleine argues we should deploy U.S. military trainers to symbolize our leadership.)

There are also differences over whether there should be conditions attached to our support following UNPROFOR withdrawal.

- NSC, DOD and Madeleine Albright argue that whatever the scope of our assistance, it should be linked to Bosnian agreement not to seek more ambitious territorial aims on the battlefield:
 - Under the NSC approach, Bosnia would need to refrain from seeking territory that would jeopardize achieving a settlement consistent with our modified Contact Group proposal.
 - Under the DOD approach, they would need to accept the territorial status quo, with the exception of being allowed to establish more secure control over Sarajevo.
- State argues that our support should be limited to defensive weapons and air support enabling the Bosnians to hold existing

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territory but that we should accept the fact they would obtain offensive weapons from other sources with which to retake additional territory. In this way, we would not be responsible for their success or failure beyond defense of their current holdings.

- Everyone agrees, however, that we should tell the Bosnians now that any U.S. military support following UNPROFOR withdrawal will be contingent on their showing flexibility in the diplomatic negotiations we will pursue in the short term.

Principals identified a number of areas where further work will be needed before we can make a final decision on these issues.

- The structure of a modified Contact Group map, reflecting new trade-offs (e.g., Muslims cede Gorazde for territory around Sarajevo), under both the more limited and more expansive objectives.
- An up-to-date analysis of the military balance, and how the Bosnians will fare when UNPROFOR leaves.
- An analysis of the military requirements (arms, training) for the Bosnians: (a) to consolidate control over the 30 percent of the territory they now control; or (b) to play on a more level field.
- The scope of the air support we would need to provide to help the Bosnians survive early Serb attacks and ways to provide that support if we were unable to act through NATO or use Italian bases or had no forward air controllers on the ground.
- The elements of an economic assistance program that we would develop with the EU to support the Bosnian Federation and, in the event of a settlement, to underpin regional reconstruction and cooperation.
- The requirements for enforcement, preferably through NATO, of an ultimate peace agreement.

Questions for Discussion

- What kind of Bosnia should be our ultimate objective?
- What will it take for a new diplomatic initiative to succeed?
- Should we take the initiative and collapse UNPROFOR this year if diplomacy fails? If UNPROFOR credibility erodes further?
- What are the impediments to "leveling the playing field" as suggested in the NSC and Albright papers?
- Could we convince the Bosnians to settle for the status quo?
- When and how should we engage our Allies in longer-range planning?

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Attachments

Tab A Memorandum from Ambassador Albright
Tab B NSC Paper: Strategy for the Balkan Conflict
Tab C OSD/JCS Paper: Bosnia Endgame/What Kind of Bosnian State?
Tab D State Paper: A Sustainable Defense of a Viable Bosnia
after UNPROFOR Withdrawal

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Clinton Presidential Records Mandatory Declassification Review

This is not a presidential record. This is used as an administrative marker by the William J. Clinton Presidential Library Staff.

Documents from this Mandatory Declassification Review were released in full.
